

Contemporary Comparative Politics & Political Institutions

A Supplementary Reading List of Core Books Published After 2000
(with a political-economy rooting, and a note on UC Berkeley affiliations)

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1 Scope and Purpose

- This is a curated (not exhaustive) supplement to the core comp-exam list, gathering major books in comparative politics and political institutions—including work with an explicit political-economy rooting—published after 2000, weighted toward the more recent literature.
- Entries are grouped by the field’s main clusters. Each carries a one-line note on why it matters or how it fits the contemporary debate.
- The final section flags authors who were on the UC Berkeley faculty during 2008–2012, per the specific interest in identifying that lineage. A caution about mis-attribution (Dunning) is included there.

2 Institutions & Comparative Political Economy

- **Peter Hall & David Soskice (eds.), *Varieties of Capitalism* (2001)** — the foundational post-2000 framework for institutional variation among rich democracies; most of CPE since responds to it.
- **Kathleen Thelen, *How Institutions Evolve* (2004) and *Varieties of Liberalization and the New Politics of Social Solidarity* (2014)** — the reference works on gradual institutional change; the 2014 book is the more contemporary statement.
- **Paul Pierson, *Politics in Time: History, Institutions, and Social Analysis* (2004)** — the canonical treatment of path dependence and temporality in institutional analysis. (Pierson → Berkeley; see §8.)
- **Torben Iversen & David Soskice, *Democracy and Prosperity* (2019)** — a major recent synthesis arguing advanced capitalism and democracy are mutually reinforcing; a useful “state of the field” capstone.
- **Daron Acemoglu & James Robinson, *Economic Origins of Dictatorship and Democracy* (2006), *Why Nations Fail* (2012), *The Narrow Corridor* (2019)** — the dominant institutionalist–political-economy sequence on regimes and development.
- **Douglass North, John Wallis & Barry Weingast, *Violence and Social Orders* (2009)** — “limited vs. open access orders”; an ambitious institutional theory of the state and violence.
- **Timothy Besley & Torsten Persson, *Pillars of Prosperity* (2011)** — state capacity (fiscal and legal) as the core institutional variable.

3 Regimes: Democracy, Authoritarianism, Backsliding

- Steven Levitsky & Lucan Way, *Competitive Authoritarianism* (2010) — defined the hybrid-regime research agenda; still the central reference. Their *Revolution and Dictatorship* (2022) extends it.
- Milan Svolik, *The Politics of Authoritarian Rule* (2012) — the leading formal-institutional account of how dictatorships manage elite and mass threats.
- Jennifer Gandhi, *Political Institutions under Dictatorship* (2008) and Beatriz Magaloni, *Voting for Autocracy* (2006) — legislatures, parties, and elections *inside* authoritarian regimes.
- Barbara Geddes, Joseph Wright & Erica Frantz, *How Dictatorships Work* (2018) — the synthesis of the large- N authoritarian-regimes program.
- Carles Boix, *Democracy and Redistribution* (2003) and *Political Order and Inequality* (2015) — inequality-based theories of regime origins and order.
- Daniel Ziblatt, *Conservative Parties and the Birth of Democracy* (2017) — why democratization succeeds or fails depending on whether the old elite can organize; excellent institutional history.
- Stephan Haggard & Robert Kaufman, *Development, Democracy, and Welfare States* (2008) and *Backsliding* (2021) — the latter is among the best recent treatments of democratic erosion.
- Dan Slater, *Ordering Power* (2010) — authoritarian durability and state-building in Southeast Asia; a modern comparative-historical classic.

4 Parties, Elections, and Distributive Politics

- Herbert Kitschelt & Steven Wilkinson (eds.), *Patrons, Clients, and Policies* (2007) and Susan Stokes, Thad Dunning, Marcelo Nazareno & Valeria Brusco, *Brokers, Voters, and Clientelism* (2013) — the anchors of the clientelism / distributive-politics literature.
- Kanchan Chandra, *Why Ethnic Parties Succeed* (2004) — patronage and ethnic mobilization.
- Pradeep Chhibber & Rahul Verma, *Ideology and Identity: The Changing Party Systems of India* (2018) — recent, and a Berkeley author (see §8).

5 Violence, Order, and State Formation

- **Stathis Kalyvas**, *The Logic of Violence in Civil War* (2006) — the defining book on wartime violence; reoriented an entire subfield.
- **James C. Scott**, *The Art of Not Being Governed* (2009) — statelessness and the limits of state reach (pairs with his 1998 *Seeing Like a State*).

6 Comparative Political Economy of the Advanced / Asian Economies

- **Steven K. Vogel**, *Japan Remodeled* (2006) and *Marketcraft: How Governments Make Markets Work* (2018) — markets as governed institutions. (Vogel is at Berkeley; see §8.)
- **Jonah Levy** (ed.), *The State after Statism* (2006) — reconfiguration of the state's economic role across rich democracies. (Levy is at Berkeley; see §8.)

7 The UC Berkeley 2008–2012 Connection

- **Paul Pierson** — moved to Berkeley in 2007 and was on the faculty throughout 2008–2012. Beyond *Politics in Time*, his co-authored *Winner-Take-All Politics* (2010, with Jacob Hacker) is a signature contemporary political-economy book on institutions and inequality.
- **Steven K. Vogel** — Berkeley faculty across that period; *Japan Remodeled* (2006) and *Marketcraft* (2018).
- **Pradeep Chhibber** — Berkeley faculty; parties and Indian politics (*Ideology and Identity*, 2018).
- **Jonah Levy**, **T. J. Pempel** (*Regime Shift*), and **Ruth Berins Collier** were also comparative / political-economy faculty there in those years, if the net is widened.
- **Caution against mis-attribution: Thad Dunning** (co-author of *Brokers, Voters, and Clientelism*) is now at Berkeley but did not join until ~2014—during 2008–2012 he was at Yale. If the “Berkeley-in-that-window” criterion is strict, lean on Pierson, Vogel, Chhibber, and Levy.

8 Optional Extensions

- **If a tighter core is wanted:** Hall & Soskice (2001), Thelen (2004), Pierson (2004), Acemoglu & Robinson (2006/2012), North–Wallis–Weingast (2009), Levitsky & Way (2010),

Svolik (2012), Boix (2003), Ziblatt (2017), Slater (2010), Kalyvas (2006), Stokes et al. (2013) make a defensible twelve.

- **If comparative methods should be added:** John Gerring, *Case Study Research* (2007); Thad Dunning, *Natural Experiments in the Social Sciences* (2012); and David Collier's work on concepts and comparison.